ENGAGE

THE MAGAZINE FOR
GALLIONS RESIDENTS
SPRNG 2014

GALLIONS
PEABODY GROUP



£30,000 up for grabs
We need your ideas!

Size matters
Transferring to a different property

Get fit for £1
New classes at Sporting Club Thamesmead

ENTER OUR GARDENING COMPETITION

Thamesmead in Bloom



ENGAGE

SPRING 2014

Engage is published four times a year for tenants and leaseholders of Peabody and Gallions. The next issue will be published in June 2014.

Editor: Kirsten Edwards
Design: Camille Neilson
Photography: Jody Kingzett; Miles Willis; David Boucher; shutterstock.com

Address all content suggestions, contest entries or comments to:
Editor, Engage, Peabody,
45 Westminster Bridge Road,
London SE1 7JB
Email: peabody.engage@peabody.org.uk

© Peabody 2014

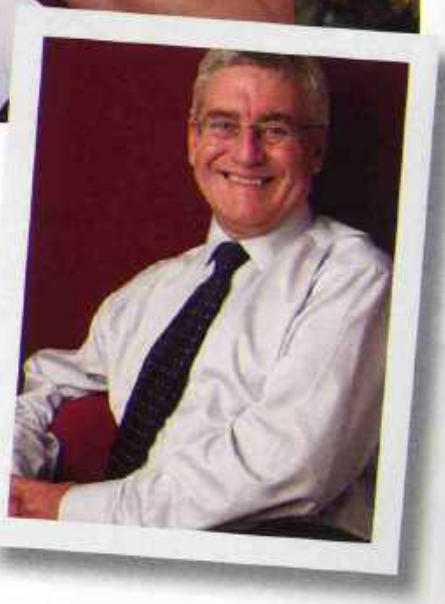
Gallions customer contact team: 0300 123 1237
Repairs contact team: 0300 123 1238
Gas appliances servicing and breakdowns: 020 8300 0300

www.gallionsha.co.uk
PeabodyLDN

Please recycle this magazine when you have finished with it



Gallions Managing Director Mandy Doe



A word from Steve Howlett

Welcome to the spring issue of *Engage*, which goes out to both Peabody and Gallions residents. Gallions officially joined the Peabody Group on 3 January and work has already begun to refurbish and regenerate Thamesmead. Look out for news of the improvements in future issues of *Engage*.

I'm sad to announce that Mandy Doe has decided to step down from her role as Managing Director at Gallions. I'm very grateful for her invaluable guidance and support throughout the merger and integration process. Mandy has been a pleasure to work with and I hope you will join me in wishing her all the very best for a long and happy retirement.

Best wishes, Steve

In this issue

03 **News**
04 **Size matters**
Moving to a different property
06 **Be fire safe**
07 **Wordsearch**
08 **Your neighbourhood**
10 **Thamesmead in Bloom**
Enter our competition
11 **How are we doing?**
Performance information

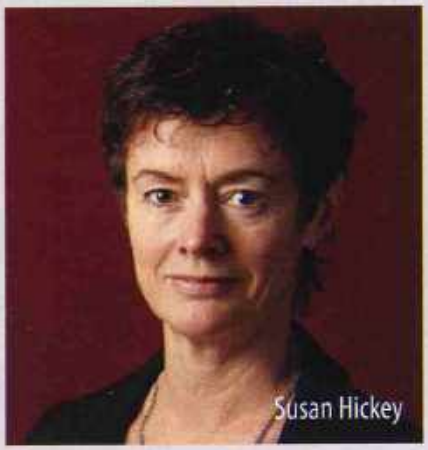
New Gallions board members

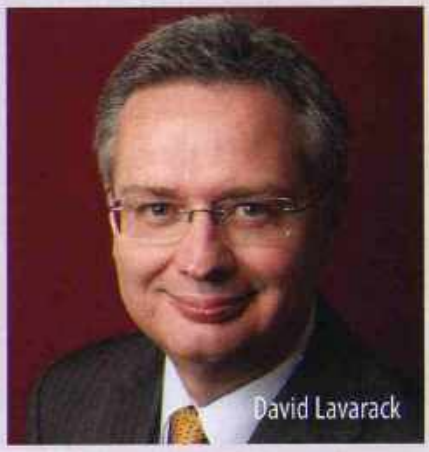
Gallions has five new board members, including two Peabody employees, Susan Hickey and David Lavarack. David is Executive Director of Corporate Services and Susan is Executive Director of Finance.

The other board members are David Avery, Malcolm Levi and Paul Hackett. David Avery has spent ten years as a member of the Saxon Weald Board and is currently Chairman of the Board of Saxon Weald Homes. He is also a founding investor and advisor to SDCmaterials Inc.

Malcolm Levi has been Chief Executive of PCHA, Warden and Home Group. He is a distinguished member of the Chartered Institute of Housing and is an advisor to a number of established boards.

Paul Hackett is Chief Executive of AmicusHorizon and has worked as the Executive Director of Development and New Business at Moat. He is a chartered surveyor and a member of the Chartered Institute of Housing.


Susan Hickey


David Lavarack



Annual customer satisfaction survey

Our annual customer satisfaction survey takes place in March and April. Voluntas, our external survey contractor, will be conducting 1,000 telephone surveys, so you may receive a call asking about your customer experience. We would appreciate it if you could take the time to answer the questions, which we use to compare our performance with other housing providers and to improve our services. The annual survey is in addition to our monthly customer satisfaction calls about services such as repairs. The results of the survey will be published on the website and in the next edition of *Engage*.

Gallions Residents Group

GRG, Gallions' resident scrutiny group, is in the process of reviewing its remit and is also looking for new members. If you are a Gallions resident and you're interested in scrutinising Gallions' services, we would love to hear from you. The role involves the following:

- Taking an objective view on the quality of services provided by Gallions.
- Reading through paperwork and keeping sensitive information confidential.
- Comparing Gallions services with those of other housing organisations.
- Talking to Gallions staff and residents.
- Working co-operatively with and talking to other Scrutiny Panel members, staff and residents.
- A willingness to learn, attending around 10 meetings and workshops during the first six months.
- Attending meetings with other Scrutiny Panel members and with officers of Gallions (these would take place approximately every two to three months).
- A willingness to offer a time commitment of approximately five to eight hours a month.

If you are interested in joining the Gallions Residents Group, and would like to find out more, please contact Kelly Sullivan on 020 7021 4381 (Monday to Wednesday) or email kelly.sullivan@peabody.org.uk.

Size matters

Welfare reform is hitting our residents hard. If you're struggling to pay your rent, we take you through your options

The government's reform of the welfare benefits system means that some Peabody and Gallions residents are having real problems trying to make ends meet. If you can't pay your rent for any reason, you must contact us straight away – our Welfare Benefits teams are always on hand to offer practical advice and support.

We know that around 700 Peabody residents and 400 Gallions residents are affected by the welfare reform act's size criteria, or bedroom tax. This means that they are no longer receiving full housing benefit as, according to government criteria, they have one or more spare bedrooms. If you have one spare bedroom, your housing benefit has been reduced by 14%; if you have two spare bedrooms, your housing benefit has been reduced by 25%.

This reduction in benefit is causing some of you to get into rent arrears. This may result in you losing your home, so it's important that you take action now. You have several options:

- Pay the difference between your rent and the amount of housing benefit you receive
- Talk to the Welfare Benefits team for help with benefit entitlements and budgeting
- Move to a smaller property – contact our lettings team (see further information, right).
- Take in a lodger – you can rent out your spare room to earn additional income, but talk to us first by calling the contact centre on the number opposite.

Who gets a bedroom?

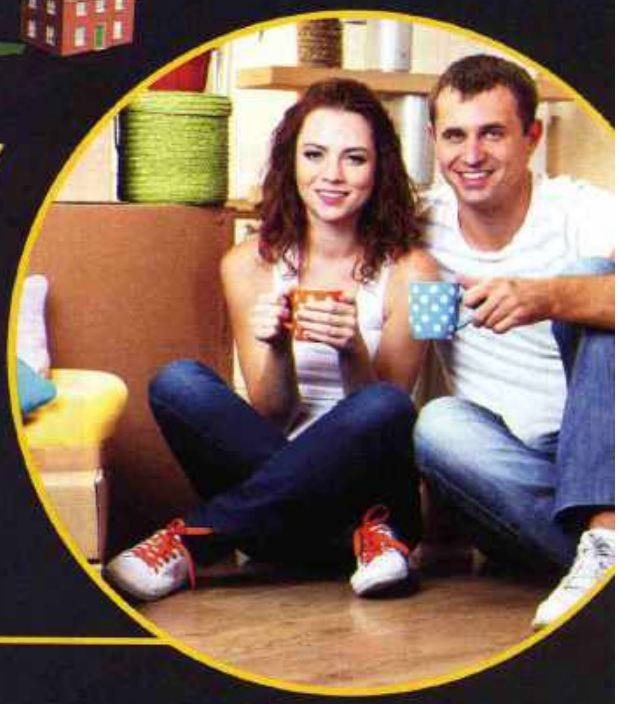
- Each single adult or each couple
- Any other person over 16
- A single child
- Two children under 16, sharing with someone of the same gender
- Two children under 10, sharing with someone of either gender
- An overnight carer – or team of carers – who do not live with you







MOVING TO ANOTHER PROPERTY



If you're affected by changes to welfare benefits, moving to a smaller property is one solution. Once your home matches your household size (see 'Who gets a bedroom', left) you will receive full housing benefit. Another bonus is that a smaller property means lower energy bills.

All Peabody and Gallions residents affected by welfare reform can apply for an internal housing transfer. Call our contact centre (see "Further information", below) to find out more about transfers.

ALTERNATIVE HOUSING OPTIONS

HOUSING MOVES

Housing Moves is a housing mobility scheme that allows tenants of London boroughs or housing associations to move to a different part of London. It is run by the Greater London Authority, and most London boroughs and housing associations are members of the scheme. Seaside and Country Homes, part of Housing Moves, is for people aged over 60.

To qualify, you need to have a clear rent account or have set up a repayment plan and maintained payments for 12 weeks. To register or to find out more, visit www.housingmoves.org.uk.

HOMEFINDER UK

This scheme allows people to find a home anywhere in the UK that better matches their household size and personal circumstances. The scheme is funded and supported by a consortium of landlords who advertise properties on the Homefinder website. To find out more, and to view the properties on offer, visit www.homefinderuk.org.

Homefinder offers a tenancy support package to all applicants to help them make a successful move. This includes advice on budgeting, welfare benefits and information on the areas you wish to move to.

LOCAL AUTHORITY WAITING LISTS

Even though you're already a Peabody or Gallions resident, you can approach your local authority to go on their housing list. However, there is no guarantee that you will be accepted, as each local authority has its own criteria. For a list of local authority contact numbers, please visit www.gov.uk.

MUTUAL EXCHANGE

Mutual exchange allows you to exchange your home with tenants from other local authorities or housing associations. This is a free service available to Peabody and Gallions residents and you could be in a new home within 42 days after finding a swap partner. To register or find out more, visit www.houseexchange.org.uk.

FURTHER INFORMATION

To find out more, contact the Gallions Welfare Benefits team on 0300 123 1237 or enquiries@gallionsha.co.uk.

Be fire safe

Every year, 226 people in the UK die in fires in their homes. You can reduce the risks by following some simple steps

Please report any fire to us as soon as you can by calling Gallions Customer Contact team on 0300 123 1237.



Smoke detectors

Smoke detectors detect fires in the early stages and sound an alarm, giving you time to leave your home in safety. According to the fire brigade, you are twice as likely to die in a fire in your home if no smoke alarm is fitted.

Many of Gallions' properties now have smoke detectors. These are normally fitted to the ceiling and connected to the mains wiring. If your home doesn't have a smoke detector, please call the Customer Contact team. We recommend that, until we fit a mains-wired smoke alarm, you install a battery-operated detector as an interim measure.

Most of our properties also have fire doors, which stop fires spreading from one flat to another. Please let us know if there are any problems with your fire doors.



To reduce the risk of fire

- Test your smoke alarms weekly.
- Make sure you put cigarettes out properly and never smoke in bed.
- Plan an escape route.
- Keep keys by doors and windows.

If there is a fire in your home

- Close the door to the room in your property where the fire is.
- Leave the building, closing the door behind you. If you live in a flat, make sure you close your front door.
- Do not stop to collect belongings.
- If your escape is blocked by fire it may be safer to stay put until the fire brigade arrives. Close the door and use towels or sheets to block any gaps to stop the smoke. Go to a window, call for help and wait to be rescued.
- If there is a lot of smoke, crawl along the floor where the air will be clearer.
- If possible, warn other people there is a fire in the building.
- If a fire alarm is fitted in your building, trigger the alarm by breaking the glass.
- Do not use the lift, if you live in a building that has one.
- Once you are safely out of the building, find a phone and call the fire brigade on 999. Give them your address, including the number of your flat and which floor the fire is on.

Further information

For more information about reducing fire risk, call Gallions on 0300 123 1237. You can also visit the London Fire Brigade website at www.london-fire@gov.uk.

Wordsearch

Words may go up, down and diagonally. Multiple-word answers may be split but the subsequent word will always start from a letter within the preceeding word or from an adjacent square. If your entry is one of the first four correctly drawn from the hat, you'll win a £25 voucher. Please send all entries to Engage Wordsearch, 45 Westminster Bridge Road, London SE1 7JB by **31 May 2014.**

V	D	R	O	N	G	G	A	O	E	V	H
O	P	A	F	P	G	N	U	M	Y	W	M
F	J	D	L	L	O	T	I	G	M	M	E
F	K	K	M	I	D	T	D	B	F	X	S
Z	L	T	R	O	G	U	A	C	M	Q	Q
G	Y	N	O	N	B	Q	F	R	T	A	L
M	A	R	I	N	E	A	F	R	Y	Q	L
O	S	R	C	H	O	C	O	L	A	T	E
S	P	M	D	V	C	R	D	R	H	A	U
S	S	V	T	E	E	A	I	A	D	F	L
O	Q	Y	C	T	N	I	L	U	J	M	S
L	L	I	S	G	N	I	H	C	T	A	H
B	B	A	T	B	U	N	N	Y	C	C	Q
L	E	Y	B	T	L	B	O	G	S	F	E
M	S	J	H	J	J	N	Y	P	J	V	L

BLOSSOM
BUNNY
CHOCOLATE
DAFFODIL
EASTER
GARDENING
HATCHING
LAMBING
OUTDOORS
SPRINGTIME

Name: _____

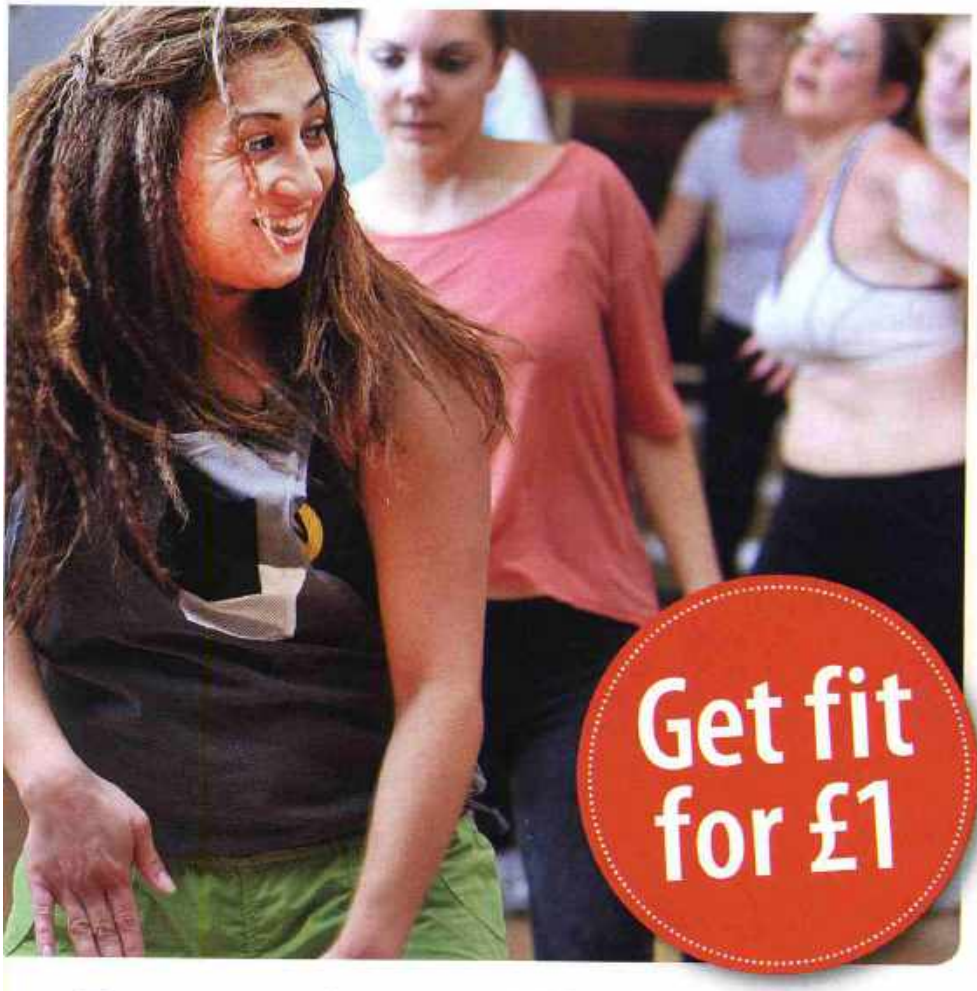
Address: _____

_____

_____

Postcode: _____

Congratulations to our winners from the Winter 2013 issue: Mr B Coleman, Muhammad Minhaj Ul Islam, Miss W Churcher, Kathleen Flood



TIMETABLE	
MONDAYS	
7–8pm	Back to Fitness (£1 per session)
8–9pm	Box Fit
TUESDAYS	
7–8pm	Zumba Basic
8–9pm	Metafit
1–2pm	Circuit
THURSDAYS	
10.30am–11.30am	Zumba Gold (£1 per session)
7.30pm–8.30pm	Metafit
FRIDAYS	
6pm–7pm	Judo (5–11 year olds)
7pm–8pm	Judo (12–65 year olds)
7–8pm	Football Fitness (£1 per session)
SATURDAYS	
9–10am	Boot Camp
SUNDAYS	
10–11am	Zumba
11am–12 noon	Yoga

Sporting Club Thamesmead

Sporting Club Thamesmead runs a number of fitness classes, and three of them – Back to Fitness, Football and Zumba Gold – cost just £1 a session. This offer is part of Sport England's Now's the Time project in partnership with Trust Thamesmead, London Borough of Bexley, Royal Borough of Greenwich, Gallions Housing Association, Peabody and Charlton Athletic Community Trust, which aims to get more people active on a regular basis.

Classes not part of the offer cost £4.50 a session (Children's Judo is £2 per class), or you can pay a monthly fee of £14.99 per month for unlimited access to classes (£9.99 per month each when you join with a friend).

Football coaching

The FA Tesco Skills Programme coaches young people in all aspects of football, including physical, psychological, technical and social skills.

Sessions take place every Tuesday during term time: 4.30pm to 5.30pm for 5–8 year olds and 5.30pm to 6.30pm for 9–11 year olds. The cost is just £2 per session. If you're interested, book now by calling Zoe on 07943 552852 or by emailing zoe.rushen@thefa.com.

Tennis

Sporting Club Thamesmead is hosting family tennis for 7-11 year olds and their parents/carers every Saturday. Classes are held in partnership with Charlton Athletic Community Trust and London Borough of Bexley and run from 11.30am to 12.30pm every Saturday. The cost is just £4 per family.

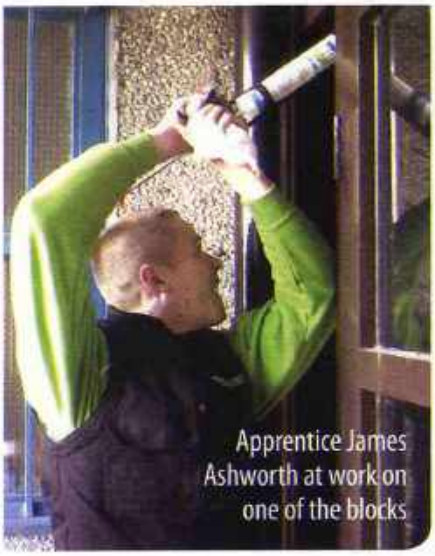
Find out more by calling Tina Johnson on 020 8331 2290 or by emailing her at tina.johnson@cact.org.uk.

Find out more

For information on classes and other activities, call 020 8320 4488, email contact@sportingclubthamesmead.co.uk or visit www.sportingclubthamesmead.co.uk. Sporting Club Thamesmead, Bayliss Avenue, Thamesmead, SE28 8NJ.

Handyman service

Team Gallions now has a new multi-trade handyman service to carry out minor repairs to communal areas in our blocks. This includes painting, glazing, door and floor repairs and other quick fixes that will keep our blocks looking smart. Dave Bellinger, who has worked with Gallions for 11 years, is our new multi-trade handyman in Thamesmead. He is working with an apprentice, James Ashworth. If you notice any repairs that need doing, call our customer contact team on 0300 1231237.

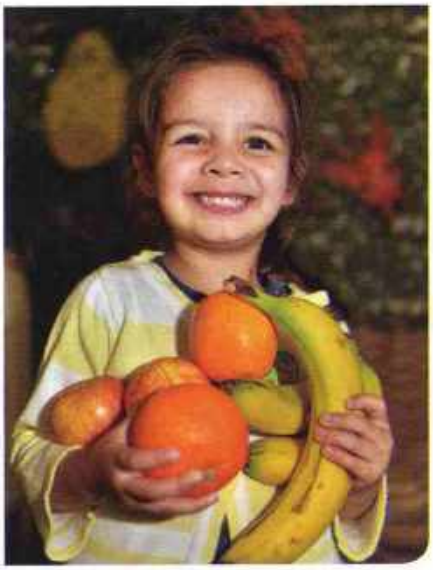


Apprentice James Ashworth at work on one of the blocks

£30,000 up for grabs

Thamesmead residents and community groups can apply for up to £5,000 to fund a project that will benefit the local area. Trust Thamesmead is working with Gallions and Bexley Council to award the grants, which will come from a 30,000 pot of money. Any person or group who's awarded a grant must match it in the form of cash, volunteering hours or resources.

If you have an idea, big or small, that would improve the area or support local people, please contact Alex Forrester on 020 8320 4470 or email aforrester@trust-thamesmead.co.uk.



Early years childcare

Trust Thamesmead runs two fantastic pre-schools in Thamesmead – Arnott and Acorn – for children aged two to five. If you are looking for a place for your child, please contact Trust Thamesmead's Childcare Manager, Tracy Norcott, at 07812 368661 or tnorcott@trust-thamesmead.co.uk.

Caretaking apprenticeship scheme

A group of young people is taking part in Gallions Environmental Services' first apprenticeship scheme. Working in partnership with Nordic Pioneer, a training organisation for cleaning and environmental services, Gallions is giving 18-24 year olds from the local area the opportunity to work and study towards an NVQ Level 2 qualification in Caretaking Services. The scheme lasts for one year, with all apprentices working as full-time Gallions employees and paid slightly over the official apprentice rate.

Eleven apprentices, including two Gallions residents, are involved in the scheme, which began last October. Their first two weeks were spent in a classroom learning about the caretaker role, and in November they were unleashed onto the Gallions Thamesmead Estate. They are assigned to individual Gallions caretakers, who act as their mentors. They will receive their qualifications when they complete the scheme and will be able to apply for any vacancies at Gallions and Peabody.



Some of the young apprentices

Thamesmead in Bloom

Enter our competition or nominate your neighbour to win up to £100 in B&Q vouchers!

Categories:

1 **Best garden**
2 **Best balcony or window box**
3 **Best community garden**
4 **Best unusual garden** (eg one that includes special plants, models and even plastic flowers!)

For a nomination form, visit the Gallions offices at **15 Joyce Dawson Way SE28 8RA** or the Trust Thamesmead office at **19a Joyce Dawson Way SE28 8RA**. Alternatively, you can complete a nomination online at **www.gallions.org.uk**. The closing date for nominations is **6 June 2014**. Judging will take place in July.
Brought to you by **The Friends of Thamesmead Parks**, supported by Gallions



How are we doing?

Each month, Gallions collects performance data to track how well we're delivering our services. The table below shows figures to end January 2014

PERFORMANCE TO JANUARY 2014

Key performance indicator	Year to 31 Jan 2014	Year-end target	On target?
% repairs completed right first time	88.14%	93%	x
% calls answered in 20 seconds	94.75%	80%	✓
Rent collected as % of rent owed	100.07%	99.50%	✓

REPAIRS

The figures for January 2014 show that repairs completed right first time fell slightly to 88.14%. This reflects the difficulties that Axis has experienced in completing roofing work, ground works and fencing because of the prolonged spell of heavy rain.



CONTACT CENTRE

Gallions contact centre is performing well above its target of 80% of calls answered within 20 seconds. Our call centre staff work hard to provide our residents with excellent customer service. We offer a one-stop shop approach, so all staff are fully trained to deal with resident queries, from rent calculations for housing benefit and antisocial behaviour reports to complaints and environmental repairs.



RENT COLLECTED

We have met our targets this month, despite the fact that welfare reform has had such a big impact on our residents, with over 411 of you affected by the bedroom tax and 16 by the benefit cap.

We are working with our New Resident team to provide mutual exchange opportunities (this is where residents exchange their home with tenants from other local authorities or housing associations), and so far 16 mutual exchanges have taken place. This means that residents are able to move to a property that better matches their household size.



To find out more, visit the performance and efficiency section of our website at www.gallionsha.co.uk.

GALLIONS
PEABODY GROUP